

Mercurial: Travis Head's impact worked on a different axis but was no less decisive. His promotion to open after tea on day two in Perth, prompted by Usman Khawaja's injury, proved a turning point. AP

ruthlessly. In Sydney, his 163 completed the picture.

Alex Carey's work behind the stumps was one of the quieter but more decisive factors in Australia's early control of the Ashes. In a series where pace dictated terms and margins were narrow, his keeping did not merely support Australia's bowlers. It amplified them.

Standing up to fast-medium bowling is not new in itself, but Carey's execution was unusually clean and consistent. At the Gabba, where Australia established a 2-0 lead, he spent long periods standing up to Scott Boland and Michael Naser, a deliberate tactic designed to pin England's batters to the crease. England's batting under Brendon McCullum and Ben Stokes relies on freedom of movement, on advancing down the pitch or rocking back to disrupt length. Carey removed that option.

The effect was immediate. Carey's reflex catch to dismiss Ben Stokes off Naser in the second innings was outstanding, taken without flinch off a thick edge. It followed a superb running catch in the first innings and set the tone for a second innings in which four of Naser's five wickets came with Carey standing up. Stokes and Will Jacks, both inclined to counter-attack, were forced into static positions, playing from the crease rather than dictating terms.

Carey's influence extended beyond Brisbane. He stood up to Boland for much of England's second innings in Adelaide, taking a sharp bat-pad catch off Jacks and helping create the conditions that led to Brydon Carse being bowled while rooted to the crease.

If England's Ashes failure had a recurring fault line, it was at No. 3, a position that has long functioned as the spine of a Test batting order. Traditionally, it is where technique meets temperament, where the



ability to absorb pressure matters as much as the capacity to score. England's history at the position reflects that importance. Ken Barrington's certainty, David Gower's authority and Jonathan Trott's refusal to yield once defined it. In this series, that lineage felt distant.

Ollie Pope's numbers are stark. Across eight Ashes Tests, 16 innings have produced 282 runs at an average of 17.62, with a highest score of 46 and no fifties or hundreds. At No. 3 in Australia, survival is currency. Pope rarely accumulated enough of it to allow England's innings to settle.

The damage went beyond individual returns. England's top order struggled to impose itself collectively. Zak Crawley's 273 runs at 27.3 hinted at promise without authority. Jamie Smith's 211 at 23.44 reflected a batter still finding his feet in alien conditions. Joe Root and Harry Brook carried much of the burden, scoring 400 and 358 runs respectively, but even their efforts were often made in recovery rather than control. Jacob Bethell's standout average of 51.25 came from just four innings and felt more like an outlier than a foundation.

Australia, by contrast, found